



Zimbabwe

Situated in southern Africa, Zimbabwe achieved independence from the UK in 1980. President Robert Mugabe, in power since then, has become increasingly authoritarian.



GEOGRAPHY

High plateaus in center bordered by Zambezi River in the north and Limpopo in the south. Rivers crisscross central area.



CLIMATE

Tropical, though moderated by the high altitude. Wet season November–March. Drought is common in the eastern highlands.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Two main ethnic groups: Shona in the north and east, and Ndebele in the south. Shona outnumber Ndebele by four to one. Whites are generally far more affluent than Blacks. Official efforts to redress this imbalance (such as land redistribution) have become increasingly aggressive. The political opposition to Mugabe joined him in a fractious unity government from 2009 in an attempt to rebuild the country.

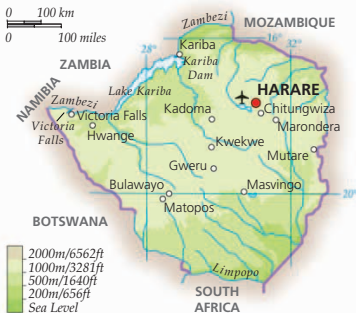


THE ECONOMY

Undermined by mismanagement, corruption, and international isolation. High unemployment. Hyperinflation. Stabilization could cost US\$45 billion.



INSIGHT: *The ruins of the 1000-year-old city of Great Zimbabwe, after which the country is named, are near modern-day Masvingo*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Zimbabwe

DATE OF FORMATION: 1980

CAPITAL: Harare

POPULATION: 12.5 million

TOTAL AREA: 150,803 sq. miles (390,580 sq. km)

DENSITY: 84 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Shona, isiNdebele, English*

RELIGIONS: Syncretic 50%, Christian 25%, traditional beliefs 24%, other 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Shona 71%, Ndebele 16%, other African 11%, White 1%, Asian 1%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Zimbabwe dollar suspended in 2009; US dollar and South African rand legal tender